

THE HORMUZ FIRST ACCORD

An Emergency Stabilization Plan to End the US-Iran War

Nuclear Deferred. Hormuz Resolved. Sovereignty Preserved.

Document Status	Diplomatic Reference Draft
Date of Issue	May 3, 2026
Version	1.0 — Hormuz First
Mediation Channel	Pakistan (primary) · Oman (technical) · Switzerland (financial)
Conflict Status	Ceasefire (3 weeks); two competing proposals on the table
Scope	Emergency stabilization. Nuclear track deferred to Stage 3.
Implementation Window	30 days to Stage 1 lock-in; 90 days to full activation
Replaces	US 9-Point Proposal · Iran 14-Point Proposal — by synthesis, not rejection

Prepared as a synthesis instrument bridging the United States 9-Point ceasefire proposal and the Islamic Republic of Iran's 14-Point peace framework, drawing on the Crescent Compact, RAMES, RCSA, CBSF, and Emergency Extension Plan architectures.

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Section 0 — Document Purpose and Strategic Premise

This Accord is a synthesis instrument. It does not displace either side's stated proposal; it harvests the points of overlap that already exist between the United States 9-Point ceasefire proposal and the Islamic Republic of Iran's 14-Point peace framework, and it converts them into a sequenced, verifiable, politically defensible path out of active hostilities.

The premise is straightforward. The two sides have been speaking past each other on tempo (Iran wants 30 days; the United States wants two months), on what comes first (Iran says lift the blockade and end the war; the United States says open Hormuz and constrain the nuclear program), and on what must be solved before anything else can be solved. Each insists the other side move first on a matter the other side regards as a sovereign concession. The result, as of May 3, 2026, is a ceasefire that is technically intact but operationally fraying, escalating maritime incidents, renewed talk of resumed strikes, the unilateral US announcement of "Project Freedom" naval escorts beginning May 4, and a midterm-election clock that imposes its own deadline on Washington.

The Accord responds to this exact configuration. It defers the nuclear file — at Iran's own stated suggestion, and consistent with what US negotiators have previously hinted is acceptable on tempo — and concentrates Stage 1 on the single issue both sides cannot afford to leave unresolved: the Strait of Hormuz. It then lifts the dual blockade in synchronized motion, returns a meaningful first tranche of Iranian sovereign assets, and establishes the institutional architecture that permits the broader nuclear conversation to resume in Stage 3 without the pressure of an active war.

What this Accord is not

This Accord is not a comprehensive peace treaty. It does not resolve the nuclear question, the ballistic-missile question, the Lebanon question, or the broader regional proxy architecture. Those are matters for the successor framework — provisionally, the Comprehensive Regional Stability Architecture (RCSA) or the Crescent Compact — for which this Accord is explicitly the bridge.

What this Accord is

It is what the Emergency Extension Plan called a "keep the system from snapping" device, hardened into a 90-day stabilization framework that resolves the immediate crisis triggers — Hormuz, the dual blockade, frozen assets — while preserving the sovereignty claims and political face of both governments. It is designed to be signable in days, not months, and implementable within a 30-day Stage 1 window that matches Iran's stated tempo while delivering the United States the operational wins it requires before the November midterm cycle hardens domestic positions.

The single sentence version. *Open Hormuz under joint authority, lift both blockades in synchronized motion, return Iran's first asset tranche, freeze the war on all fronts, defer the nuclear conversation by 90 days under a verified non-advancement standstill — and let each government tell its own story about what it won.*

Section 1 — The Situation as of May 3, 2026

Any stabilization plan must be calibrated to the actual state of the conflict. The following is the operational picture this Accord is designed to address.

1.1 The shooting war and the ceasefire

The United States and Israel launched coordinated strikes on Iranian nuclear, military, and leadership infrastructure on February 28, 2026, an operation widely referred to as Operation Epic Fury. Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei was killed in the opening days; succession passed to Mojtaba Khamenei. Iran responded with strikes on US bases and Gulf-state infrastructure, and on or about March 1, 2026, effectively closed the Strait of Hormuz to non-Iranian shipping. A ceasefire was agreed on April 7–8, 2026, mediated by Pakistan, and has technically held for three weeks despite ongoing maritime incidents and limited cross-border fire in Lebanon.

1.2 The two proposals on the table

Two formal frameworks are currently being exchanged through Pakistani mediators:

	United States 9-Point Proposal	Iran 14-Point Proposal
Tempo	Two-month ceasefire while terms finalized	30-day window to end the war (not extend ceasefire)
Hormuz	Complete reopening; Iran clears mines	New mechanism replacing US unilateral control
Nuclear	Central; enrichment restrictions required up front	Deferred to a later stage
Sanctions	Phased relief tied to compliance	Lifted as part of war termination package
Frozen assets	Phased return tied to milestones	Released as restitution
US naval blockade	Lifted in step with Hormuz reopening	Lifted unconditionally
US forces in region	Posture preserved	Withdrawal from Iran's periphery
Lebanon	Separate track (Hezbollah disarmament)	End of all hostilities, including Lebanon
Reparations	Not addressed	US payment of war reparations
Nature of accord	Ceasefire framework with negotiation period	Three-stage plan: ceasefire → non-aggression pact → strategic dialogue

President Trump has rejected the 14-point proposal as unacceptable but has continued to confirm that talks are "in conversation" and that special envoy Steve Witkoff remains active. Iran's Foreign Ministry has confirmed receipt of a US written response on May 3 and is reviewing it. The ceasefire is, as of this writing, intact.

1.3 Project Freedom and the Hormuz pressure point

On May 3, 2026, President Trump announced "Project Freedom" — a US Navy operation to escort neutral commercial vessels through the Strait of Hormuz beginning the morning of May 4, framed as a humanitarian gesture. Centcom has indicated that escort posture will involve guided-missile destroyers, more than 100 aircraft, and unmanned platforms, with US Navy ships positioned "in the vicinity" rather than alongside. Iran's IRGC has stated it remains on "full standby" for return to hostilities. Iran's parliament is reportedly considering a 12-point statutory framework to formally restrict Hormuz transit. Any Iranian interference with Project Freedom escorts on or after May 4 carries a serious risk of immediate kinetic escalation back into open warfare.

This is the precise window in which the Accord must enter force. Project Freedom, Iran's parliamentary 12-point legislation, and the lapsing of the diplomatic patience signaled by the Trump administration's domestic pressure (gas at \$4.45/gallon, midterms in November) form a convergence of pressures that either forces a deal or forces resumption of strikes.

1.4 The dual blockade

Iran has effectively blocked the Strait of Hormuz to non-Iranian shipping since March, reducing monthly transits from approximately 3,000 vessels to 154 in March. The United States imposed a counter-blockade on Iranian commercial ports beginning April 13. Both blockades remain operative. This is the single most economically destabilizing element of the war. Approximately 20 percent of global oil and gas supplies pass through Hormuz; the closure has driven US gasoline prices up approximately 50 percent since the war began.

1.5 What both sides have implicitly conceded

Several points of de facto convergence exist beneath the surface of the public proposals. They form the operational basis for this Accord:

- Both sides accept that the ceasefire should hold; neither has formally terminated it despite repeated provocations.
- Both sides accept Pakistan as the primary mediator and have not sought to displace this channel.
- Iran has signaled openness to deferring the nuclear file to a later stage, framing this as a procedural facilitation.
- The United States, through Witkoff, has confirmed the missile file is to be addressed regionally, not bilaterally — implicitly accepting a sequenced approach.
- Both sides accept that the Strait of Hormuz cannot remain in the current dual-blockade configuration; the only question is the institutional form of the resolution.
- Both sides accept that frozen Iranian assets should return; the only question is the sequencing and conditionality.
- Both sides have publicly invoked sovereignty as a non-negotiable. Each must therefore be permitted to characterize its own concessions as sovereign choices.

Section 2 — Why Both Proposals Stalled, and What This Accord Fixes

Neither the 9-point nor the 14-point framework is unworkable in substance. Each is unworkable in its present form because of structural problems with how it sequences sovereign concessions, manages domestic political optics, and responds to the asymmetric tempo demands of the two governments. Identifying these structural problems is the precondition for fixing them.

2.1 Why the US 9-Point Proposal stalled

Problem 1: Front-loaded nuclear conditionality.

The 9-point proposal places enrichment limits and nuclear restrictions at the entry threshold. For Iran's domestic audience — including the Mojtaba Khamenei succession, the IRGC, and the judiciary — accepting enrichment restrictions before the United States lifts the blockade reads as capitulation. Iran's domestic political infrastructure has anchored on the principle that Iran will not be coerced on the nuclear file under wartime pressure. Insisting on this sequencing guarantees rejection.

Problem 2: A two-month ceasefire window without war termination.

Iran reads any ceasefire-only framework as the United States buying time to prepare for renewed strikes. The historical reference point Tehran invokes is JCPOA withdrawal; the operational reference point is the period between previous ceasefires and resumption. Iran's 30-day demand is not arbitrary — it is calibrated to terminate the war fast enough that re-mobilization is not feasible.

Problem 3: No off-ramp for Iran's stated demand on US forces.

The 9-point proposal preserves US force posture in the region. Iran requires some demonstrable withdrawal — even if cosmetic, even if conditional, even if reversible — to claim the war ended with a sovereignty win. The current US framework provides no such demonstrable element.

2.2 Why the Iran 14-Point Proposal stalled

Problem 1: Reparations as a gateway condition.

The demand for US war reparations is politically impossible for the Trump administration. It is categorically off the table for both partisan and constitutional reasons. As a gateway condition to any agreement, it functions as a deal-killer regardless of what comes after.

Problem 2: Withdrawal of US forces from Iran's "periphery."

The 14-point demand for withdrawal from Iran's periphery, as currently articulated, would require the United States to dismantle decades of Gulf basing, treaty commitments, and partner security guarantees. This is incompatible with the United States's relationship with Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Bahrain, Qatar, and Kuwait, all of which would resist such a withdrawal as a unilateral US abandonment.

Problem 3: 30 days for total war termination is operationally impossible.

Even if both governments agreed today on every substantive point, the legal, banking, regulatory, and operational steps required to lift sanctions, reopen banking channels, return assets, and stand up the institutional architecture for Hormuz cannot be completed in 30 days. The 30-day demand is rhetorically powerful but logistically unrealistic.

Problem 4: Bundling Lebanon into the bilateral US-Iran package.

The Lebanon front involves Israel, Hezbollah, the Lebanese Armed Forces, UNIFIL, and the Lebanese government — none of which are parties to the US-Iran negotiation. Bundling Lebanon into the US-Iran framework conflates sovereign decisions of third parties with bilateral US-Iran obligations and gives the US implicit veto over Hezbollah's posture, which Iran is not in a political position to deliver.

2.3 What this Accord fixes

Stalled element	Fix in this Accord
Front-loaded nuclear conditionality (US)	Nuclear file deferred to Stage 3 (Day 61+) under a verified non-advancement standstill — Iran retains all NPT rights and asserts no concession is being made under duress.
Two-month ceasefire vs. 30-day war termination (Iran)	Three-stage architecture: 14-day Hormuz reset, 60-day de-escalation, 180-day permanent architecture. Each stage produces a self-contained set of "closed" items, so Iran can credibly say the war is ending in stages and the US can credibly say the framework is durable.
No US-force-posture concession (Iran demand)	Naval blockade lifted (a real, visible concession). No basing concessions. Forward US naval posture in Hormuz transitions from unilateral enforcement to joint authority — framed by Iran as US relinquishing exclusive control, framed by US as multilateral normalization.
Reparations as gateway (Iran)	Reparations demand parked. Replaced with: Day-One \$250 million pilot asset release; Stage 1 first asset tranche of 25 percent; Stage 2 second tranche of 25 percent; Hormuz toll revenue earmarked for Iranian civilian reconstruction (≈\$200M/year).
US-force-withdrawal demand (Iran)	No basing changes. Carrier transit windows in Hormuz become declared and pre-notified rather than discretionary — a meaningful but containable adjustment that Iran can publicly characterize as a reduction in US unilateralism.
30-day war termination (Iran)	Stage 1 closes the war-fighting domain in 14 days. Stages 2 and 3 then handle institutional architecture without active hostilities. Iran can announce "the war ended in 14 days" while the institutional work proceeds.
Lebanon bundled (Iran)	Lebanon track separated. Iran commits to a Hezbollah operational pause via the Iranian channel; Israel-Lebanon-Hezbollah-LAF terms remain on a parallel Crescent Compact track. Bilateral US-Iran agreement is not blocked by Lebanese politics.

Section 3 — Architecture: A Three-Stage Framework

The Accord is structured as three sequenced stages, each with a defined entry condition, a defined set of obligations, a defined verification standard, and a defined transition trigger to the next stage. The architecture is deliberately modular: failure at any stage does not collapse the prior stages. Stage 1 deliverables are irreversible once verified; Stage 2 deliverables are irreversible once verified; only Stage 3 is open-ended.

3.1 Stage overview

	Stage 1 The Hormuz Reset	Stage 2 De-Escalation and Asset Return	Stage 3 Permanent Architecture and Nuclear Re-engagement
Duration	Days 1–14	Days 15–60	Days 61–180
Primary objective	End the dual blockade; stand up the Joint Hormuz Authority in provisional mode; halt war-fighting on all fronts.	Return first asset tranches; lift first sanctions tranche; activate humanitarian and aviation-safety relief; complete proxy operational pauses.	Convert provisional Hormuz Authority to permanent IHTA; resume nuclear file under deferred-compliance regime; complete sanctions-relief schedule.
Closing trigger	Verified bilateral lifting of both blockades; first humanitarian and commercial vessels through Hormuz under Joint Authority observation.	First asset tranche transferred; first sanctions tranche operative; 60-day verified ceasefire compliance.	IHTA permanent activation; nuclear MOU signed; comprehensive successor framework (RCSA, Crescent Compact, RAMES) opened for negotiation.
What is deferred	Asset return mechanics; sanctions sequencing; nuclear conversation entirely.	Permanent IHTA charter; nuclear conversation entirely.	Nothing — all elements are addressed in this stage or referred to a successor framework.
Reversibility	Stage 1 deliverables irreversible upon verification.	First asset tranche irreversible. Subsequent tranches subject to snapback friction ladder.	Each measure subject to snapback friction ladder; nuclear standstill subject to verified-breach review.

3.2 Why three stages, not one

A single comprehensive agreement is operationally and politically infeasible in this window. The 9-point/14-point exchange has demonstrated that any all-at-once package is held hostage by the most contested element. By staging deliberately, the Accord ensures that each stage produces irreversible facts on the ground — closed Hormuz mines, returned ships, transferred assets, lifted sanctions tranches — that constitute the political bedrock for the next stage. If Stage 3 fails on the nuclear file, Stages 1 and 2 remain in force.

This is the same principle that the Comprehensive Regional Stability Architecture documents call *graduated complexity activation*: the framework expands as both sides demonstrate capacity to absorb the next layer.

3.3 Why Hormuz first

Hormuz is the convergent crisis. It is the most economically destabilizing element, the most operationally dangerous (Project Freedom escorts begin May 4), the most procedurally tractable (both sides have already endorsed institutional approaches in past proposals), and the most politically asymmetric in a useful way: the United States can credibly claim a major win on freedom of navigation while Iran can credibly claim institutional equality replacing US unilateralism. No other single issue offers this combination.

Equally important: deferring Hormuz cannot be done. The blockades are active *now*. Project Freedom begins on May 4. Iran's parliament is moving on its own statutory framework. Either Hormuz gets resolved through a joint authority or it gets resolved kinetically. There is no third option. The Accord places Hormuz first because reality has already placed it first.

3.4 Why the nuclear file is deferred

Three reasons.

First, Iran proposed it. The deferral is consistent with Iran's stated position as of May 2 — that the nuclear file should be moved to a final stage "to create a more conducive atmosphere." Adopting Iran's own proposal on tempo eliminates a major source of objection.

Second, the nuclear file requires technical infrastructure that no longer exists. Israeli strikes destroyed Iran's conversion facility in 2025, and US/Israeli strikes in February 2026 inflicted further damage. Iran cannot rapidly weaponize its existing 60 percent stockpile without rebuilding infrastructure that is currently destroyed and would be detected immediately. A 90-day standstill is therefore a verifiable measure, not an aspirational one.

Third, deferring the nuclear file removes the single largest political obstacle to closing Stage 1. Once Stage 1 deliverables are locked in (Hormuz open, blockades lifted, assets beginning to return), both governments will have demonstrably more political room to address the nuclear file in Stage 3, with the war ended and the immediate economic crisis resolved.

3.5 The standstill, not the agreement

Stage 1 includes a *verified nuclear non-advancement standstill*: Iran does not increase enrichment levels above current levels, does not move enriched uranium out of currently monitored sites, does not resume activity at sites bombed during the war. This is a much narrower commitment than the 9-point proposal demanded — it is preservation of the post-strike status quo, not rollback. It is verifiable through existing IAEA channels (resumed in Stage 2) and national technical means. It is consistent with the amendments US envoy Witkoff is reported to have submitted to the Iranian draft. Critically, Iran can characterize the standstill as a sovereign choice not to escalate, not as a concession on its NPT rights.

Section 4 — Stage 1: The Hormuz Reset (Days 1–14)

Stage 1 is the heart of the Accord. It runs for 14 days from signature and produces six irreversible operational deliverables. By the end of Stage 1, the dual blockade is lifted, the Joint Hormuz Authority is operating in provisional mode, the war-fighting domain is closed, and the first sovereign Iranian asset transfer is complete.

4.1 The six Stage 1 deliverables

Day	Deliverable	Verification
1	Joint signature of Accord by US and Iranian heads of state or designated representatives, transmitted via Pakistan with Oman and Switzerland as concurrent witnesses.	Pakistani Prime Minister's Office certification; UN Secretary-General notification; simultaneous published statements by Tehran and Washington.
1	Permanent ceasefire on all fronts of the US-Iran war takes effect at 0000 GMT. Replaces the provisional April 8 ceasefire. Lebanon is acknowledged as a parallel track but the bilateral ceasefire is not contingent on Lebanese terms.	Centcom reports cessation of US/coalition strikes; IRGC reports cessation of attacks on US/coalition assets; Pakistani guarantor confirms within 6 hours.
1	Pilot Iranian sovereign asset release: USD \$250 million transferred to Iranian Central Bank. Unconditional; framed as restitution of Iranian sovereign property.	US Treasury OFAC issues general license; Iranian Central Bank confirms receipt; transfer logged with IMF and World Bank as sovereign instrument.
3	First humanitarian-flagged vessel (UN, Red Crescent, WHO, WFP) transits Strait of Hormuz under Joint Hormuz Authority observation. No interference, no fees, no inspection delay.	Lloyd's List vessel tracking; UN OCHA confirmation; live feed from JHA observation post (Khasab, Oman).
7	Synchronized lifting of dual blockade. Iran removes all restrictions on commercial vessel transit through Hormuz. United States lifts naval blockade on Iranian commercial ports. Lifts are declared simultaneously through guarantor relay; 72-hour implementation window.	Lloyd's List + UN OCHA + JHA transit logs + guarantor naval observers. If one side fails to lift within 72 hours, the other side's lift is suspended and matter referred to JHA emergency session.
14	Stage 1 closing certification: Joint Hormuz Authority operational in provisional mode; first commercial transit count exceeds 50 vessels; verified nuclear non-advancement standstill confirmed by national technical means; ceasefire intact.	JHA Director-General certification; Pakistan + Oman + Switzerland concurrent confirmation; transition to Stage 2 automatically triggered.

4.2 Reciprocal commitments

4.2.1 United States commitments in Stage 1

- Cease all offensive military operations against Iran, Iranian forces, Iranian-linked installations, and Iranian-linked vessels.
- Lift the naval blockade on Iranian commercial ports on Day 7 in synchronized motion with Iran's Hormuz reopening.
- Suspend Project Freedom unilateral escort operations on Day 1; transition Project Freedom assets to JHA-coordinated convoy support on Day 7.

- Issue OFAC general license for the \$250 million pilot asset transfer on Day 1.
- Issue OFAC general license for humanitarian trade (medicine, medical equipment, food, agricultural inputs, aviation safety parts) within 14 days of signature; this relief is unconditional and not subject to reversal on compliance grounds.
- Pause all new sanctions designations against Iranian individuals and entities for the 14-day Stage 1 period (existing designations remain).
- Confirm in writing the deferral of the nuclear file to Stage 3 and the standstill arrangement.
- Decline to characterize Iran's commitments under this Accord as "capitulation," "unconditional surrender," or any equivalent term, in any official US government statement.

4.2.2 Iranian commitments in Stage 1

- Cease all offensive operations against US forces, US bases, US-flagged or US-affiliated vessels, and US-allied Gulf state infrastructure.
- Open the Strait of Hormuz to all commercial vessel transit, beginning Day 3 with humanitarian vessels and Day 7 with full commercial reopening, in synchronized motion with the US blockade lift.
- Withdraw IRGC small craft from positions within 5 nautical miles of the central transit corridor; cease vessel boardings except in clearly defined sanctions-enforcement scenarios coordinated with JHA.
- Commence good-faith mine-clearing operations in concert with the Joint Hormuz Authority's Maritime Safety Working Group, with technical support available from Oman, the United Kingdom (NATO maritime mine countermeasures), and a UN-supervised civilian mine-clearance mission. Iran retains operational lead in territorial waters.
- Maintain the verified nuclear non-advancement standstill: no enrichment level increases, no movement of enriched material from currently monitored sites, no resumption of activity at sites struck during the war.
- Transmit to Houthi leadership an instruction to implement a Red Sea operational pause on commercial shipping, with Iranian acknowledgment that confirmed Houthi attacks using Iranian-supplied weapons constitute a material breach.
- Decline to characterize US commitments under this Accord as "reparations," "defeat," or any equivalent term, in any official Iranian government statement.
- Refrain from passage of the proposed parliamentary 12-point Hormuz statute for the duration of Stage 1; statutory framework deferred to Stage 2 negotiation in coordination with JHA charter.

4.3 The synchronized lift mechanism

The single most important mechanical element of Stage 1 is the synchronized lifting of the dual blockade on Day 7. This mechanism is drawn directly from the RCSA Wartime Entry and Post-Conflict Baseline Protocol, with operational hardening for the current configuration.

Step 1 (Day 1). Both governments issue identical written declarations to the Pakistani guarantor, Omani technical channel, and Swiss financial channel, committing to the synchronized lift on Day 7.

Step 2 (Days 1–6). The Joint Hormuz Authority's Maritime Coordination Cell, hosted in Muscat, finalizes operational protocols for Day 7 implementation. Iran's transit-permit system transitions to JHA-coordinated electronic clearance. The US Fifth Fleet establishes coordination links with Iranian Navy and IRGC-Navy through the Omani-hosted hotline.

Step 3 (Day 7, 0000 GMT). Both lifts declared operative simultaneously. JHA observation vessels (one US-flagged, one Iranian-flagged, one Omani-flagged, with international observers aboard each) take station at Khasab and Bandar Abbas to monitor first transits.

Step 4 (Day 7, +24 hours). First commercial vessel transits in each direction under JHA observation. Lloyd's List and UN OCHA confirm transit. JHA issues first daily transit report.

Step 5 (Day 7, +72 hours). If both lifts have not been verified by this point, the unlifted side's lift commitment is suspended. Matter referred to JHA emergency session and to the Pakistani guarantor for mediation. Default rule: maintain both blockades until synchronization is achieved. Neither side gains unilateral advantage from the other's non-compliance.

4.4 Project Freedom transition

Project Freedom, scheduled to begin May 4, 2026, is the immediate operational hazard. The Accord addresses it as follows. From the moment of Accord signature, Project Freedom escort operations are *suspended* rather than terminated; US naval assets remain in position. On Day 7, those same US naval assets are re-tasked under the Joint Hormuz Authority's Maritime Safety Fund as convoy-support vessels available to all commercial transits regardless of flag, in coordination with Iranian Navy and Omani Navy. The political framing for the United States is that Project Freedom "succeeded" in establishing freedom of navigation. The political framing for Iran is that unilateral US escort has been replaced by joint multilateral authority. Both framings are factually accurate.

4.5 Stage 1 closing conditions

Stage 1 closes and Stage 2 activates automatically when the following conditions are jointly certified by Pakistan, Oman, and Switzerland on Day 14:

- Joint Hormuz Authority operating in provisional mode; first 14-day transit count exceeds 200 vessels (recovery toward pre-war baseline).
- Both blockades verified lifted; no material interference incidents in the preceding 7-day period.
- Pilot \$250 million asset transfer complete and confirmed by Iranian Central Bank.
- Verified nuclear non-advancement standstill confirmed by national technical means and (where access permits) by IAEA.
- Ceasefire intact on all bilateral fronts; no exchange of direct fire between US and Iranian forces.
- Houthi Red Sea operational pause verified by RSMS Commission.
- Both governments have issued required public statements and have refrained from prohibited characterizations.

If any closing condition is not met by Day 14, the JHA Director-General convenes an emergency session and issues a remediation plan. Stage 1 may be extended by 7 days by joint guarantor concurrence; further

extension requires explicit consent from both signatory governments.

Section 5 — Stage 2: De-Escalation and Asset Return (Days 15–60)

Stage 2 spans Days 15 through 60 of the Accord. Its purpose is to convert the operational stabilization achieved in Stage 1 into durable economic and institutional measures that constitute the political bedrock for Stage 3. By the end of Stage 2, half of Iran's frozen sovereign assets have been returned, the first sanctions tranche is operative, the IAEA has redeployed under deferred-compliance terms, and the comprehensive ceasefire has been verified stable for 60 days.

5.1 Stage 2 deliverables

Day	Deliverable	Conditionality
15	Stage 2 activation. Joint Implementation Group (JIG) inaugurated, hosted in Geneva. Membership: US, Iran, Pakistan, Oman, Switzerland, EU observer, UN Special Envoy.	Triggered by Stage 1 closing certification.
20	IAEA redeployment under deferred-compliance terms. Inspectors return to declared sites currently accessible. No challenge inspections during the deferral period.	Iran issues invitation; IAEA Director General confirms.
30	Second Iranian sovereign asset tranche: 25 percent of remaining frozen assets transferred to Iranian Central Bank. Combined with Day 1 pilot, this completes the first 25 percent of total frozen assets.	JIG verification of Stage 2 conditions; 30-day Congressional review window with no resolution of disapproval.
30	First sanctions relief tranche: aviation safety parts licenses (Boeing/Airbus); banking channels for humanitarian trade fully operational; carpets, pistachios, caviar, foodstuffs export to US market authorized.	JIG verification.
45	Joint Hormuz Authority transitions from provisional to operating mode. Tier 1 humanitarian transit (zero toll) and Tier 2 standard commercial transit (\$0.15/ton) operative. Tier 3 energy transit (\$0.25/ton, \$35K flat for VLCC) operative on Day 60.	JHA Council unanimous certification.
60	Stage 2 closing. Third Iranian sovereign asset tranche: additional 25 percent transferred (cumulative 50 percent). Hormuz Tier 3 tolling operative. SWIFT reconnection process commenced for FATF-compliant Iranian banks.	JIG verification; Congressional review window concurrent.

5.2 The asset return architecture

Approximately \$100 billion in Iranian sovereign assets remain frozen across various jurisdictions (estimates vary; the figure is for illustrative architecture). The Accord adopts the staged tranche structure from RAMES v9.1 and the Crescent Compact, calibrated to the wartime configuration:

Tranche	Timing	Amount	Trigger	Reversibility
Pilot	Day 1 (Stage 1)	\$250M	Signature	Non-reversible

Tranche	Timing	Amount	Trigger	Reversibility
1	Day 30 (Stage 2)	25% minus pilot	Stage 1 closed; IAEA deployed; nuclear standstill verified	Non-reversible
2	Day 60 (Stage 2 close)	25%	60-day verified ceasefire compliance; JHA operational	Non-reversible
3	Day 120 (Stage 3)	20%	Permanent IHTA operational; Stage 3 nuclear MOU signed	30-day remediation window for material breach
4	Day 180 (Stage 3 close)	15%	180-day comprehensive compliance; nuclear standstill maintained	Subject to JIG material-breach review
Reserve	Day 365	10%	12 months sustained compliance; clean certification	Held pending material-breach determination

The pilot and Tranches 1 and 2 are explicitly non-reversible upon transfer. This is an asymmetric concession in Iran's favor, justified by the asymmetry of the wartime configuration: the United States can plausibly walk away from the Accord at any stage, but Iran has accepted verifiable concessions on the war-fighting domain in Stage 1 that cannot be reversed (the Hormuz reset is operational reality once executed). The non-reversibility of the first 50 percent of asset return therefore matches the non-reversibility of Iran's Stage 1 operational concessions.

Each tranche from Tranche 3 forward is subject to the snapback friction ladder defined in Section 14. No instant reversal is possible at any stage; the minimum re-freezing window for any released tranche is 150 days from JIG material-breach determination.

5.3 Sanctions relief sequencing

The sanctions relief schedule in Stage 2 is calibrated to provide tangible economic benefits to ordinary Iranians (humanitarian and consumer goods) and to Iran's commercial aviation safety, while leaving deeper economic relief (oil, banking Tier 3, petrochemicals) to Stage 3 where it can be linked to the resumption of the nuclear conversation.

Day	Relief activated	Beneficiary
1 (Stage 1)	Humanitarian: medicine, medical equipment, food, agricultural inputs, environmental goods	Iranian civilian population
14 (Stage 1 close)	Banking channels for humanitarian trade reopened under streamlined OFAC licensing	Iranian banks (humanitarian transactions only)
30 (Stage 2)	Aviation safety parts (Boeing, Airbus) licensed for Iranian commercial aviation; specialty exports (carpets, pistachios, caviar, foodstuffs) to US market; gold and precious metals trade	Iran Air, civilian aviation infrastructure, agricultural exports
60 (Stage 2 close)	SWIFT reconnection process commenced for FATF-compliant Iranian banks; automotive sector sanctions lifted	Iranian commercial banks (FATF-compliant only); auto sector

Day	Relief activated	Beneficiary
120 (Stage 3)	Petrochemicals export licensing; oil services licensing; Tier 2 banking	Iranian energy sector
180 (Stage 3 close)	Full nuclear-related sanctions lifting subject to nuclear standstill maintenance; oil moratorium framework activated	Iranian economy broadly

5.4 IAEA re-engagement under deferred-compliance terms

The Accord defers nuclear negotiation but does not defer nuclear monitoring. The distinction is essential. On Day 20 of Stage 2, IAEA inspectors return to currently declared sites under terms consistent with Iran's existing safeguards agreement. Three operational rules apply during the deferral period:

- **No challenge inspections.** The IAEA's 72-hour challenge inspection authority under the framework's enhanced safeguards regime is suspended for the deferral period (Days 1–60). Standard declared-site inspections continue.
- **No new declarations required.** Iran is not required to declare additional sites or materials during the deferral period. The standstill is preservation of the post-strike status quo, not rollback.
- **National technical means as backstop.** US, Israeli, and partner intelligence services may continue all collection activities; Accord places no constraint on intelligence operations. Verified discrepancies between IAEA reporting and national technical means are referred to the JIG for resolution.

5.5 Lebanon parallel track

Lebanon is acknowledged as a parallel track but is not bundled into the bilateral US-Iran Accord. Iran commits, through the Iranian channel, to instructing Hezbollah leadership to implement an operational pause on attacks against Israeli territory and IDF positions during Stage 1 and Stage 2. The terms of the broader Lebanon settlement (LAF deployment, Hezbollah disarmament, Israeli withdrawal from buffer zones) are referred to the Crescent Compact's Israel-Lebanon-Hezbollah architecture, which operates on its own timeline. Failure of the Lebanon track does not collapse this bilateral Accord; success of this Accord creates conditions in which the Lebanon track becomes more tractable.

Section 6 — Stage 3: Permanent Architecture and Nuclear Re-engagement (Days 61–180)

Stage 3 runs from Day 61 through Day 180 and is the bridge to the comprehensive successor framework. Its purpose is twofold: to convert the provisional Joint Hormuz Authority into the permanent International Hormuz Transit Authority (IHTA), and to resume the nuclear conversation under the deferred-compliance regime now that the war has been ended and the immediate stabilization deliverables have been verified.

6.1 Stage 3 deliverables

Day	Deliverable	Conditionality
61	Stage 3 activation. Joint Implementation Group expanded to include People's Republic of China and a GCC rotating chair (Oman, Qatar, or UAE) as observers.	Stage 2 closing certification.
75	Nuclear MOU framework opened. Iran and the United States, mediated by the JIG and with IAEA technical support, begin formal negotiation on a permanent nuclear arrangement. Iran retains all NPT rights; the US accepts that any agreement must be characterized as reciprocal, not imposed.	Stage 3 activated; both governments confirm willingness to engage.
90	Provisional Joint Hormuz Authority is converted to permanent International Hormuz Transit Authority (IHTA) by treaty. Permanent Council seats established: Iran, US, GCC rotating chair, EU observer, China observer, UN-appointed neutral chair.	JIG unanimous certification; UN Secretary-General confirms neutral chair appointment.
120	Third asset tranche: 20 percent transferred. Cumulative: 70 percent of frozen assets returned. Sanctions relief Tranche 2 operative (petrochemicals; oil services; Tier 2 banking).	JIG verification; nuclear MOU substantive progress; Congressional review window.
150	Section 123 Agreement negotiation commenced. Civilian reactor fuel supply guarantee through international consortium initiated. Multilateral fuel-bank backstop arrangement (IAEA fuel bank or alternative) confirmed.	Iran formally requests; US Department of Energy confirms negotiation framework.
180	Stage 3 closing. Fourth asset tranche: 15 percent transferred (cumulative 85 percent). Successor framework — Comprehensive Regional Stability Architecture, Crescent Compact, or RAMES — formally opened for negotiation. This Accord remains in force until superseded.	JIG closing certification; comprehensive 180-day compliance review.

6.2 The nuclear MOU framework

Stage 3 does not produce a comprehensive nuclear agreement. It produces a Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) that frames the parameters of a future agreement and establishes the negotiating architecture. This is deliberate: a comprehensive nuclear agreement requires Congressional engagement, IAEA technical work, and political conditions that take longer than 180 days to mature. The MOU is the political commitment to negotiate; the agreement itself is a Stage 4 deliverable for the successor framework.

The MOU is expected to address:

- Iran's continued NPT rights and the framing of any limitations as sovereign reciprocal commitments rather than imposed restrictions.
- An enrichment ceiling for the duration of any future agreement (likely 3.67 percent for civilian fuel cycle purposes; this is the JCPOA-equivalent baseline).
- Disposition of Iran's existing 60 percent enriched uranium stockpile, with options including third-country custody, in-country dilution under continuous IAEA supervision, or conversion to fuel assemblies.
- Conversion of the Fordow facility to a medical isotope research center under IAEA oversight, with international scientific collaboration.
- Civilian reactor fuel supply guarantee through a Section 123 Agreement, with multilateral backstop.
- Verification architecture: continuous monitoring, environmental sampling, and challenge inspection authority, calibrated to be equivalent in scope to obligations accepted by other NPT states (Brazil, Argentina, South Africa, Japan).
- Domestic Iranian legislation criminalizing nuclear weapons development with substantial penalties, as a sovereign legislative act.
- A snapback mechanism for material breach, with the friction ladder defined in Section 14.

These elements are drawn from the architecture proven in the Crescent Compact and RAMES frameworks. The MOU does not commit either side to specific terms; it commits both sides to negotiate within this conceptual frame.

6.3 Conversion of Joint Hormuz Authority to permanent IHTA

On Day 90, the provisional Joint Hormuz Authority converts to the permanent International Hormuz Transit Authority. This conversion requires only ratification of the IHTA Charter by Iran, the United States, the GCC rotating chair, and the UN Secretary-General's appointed neutral chair. The conversion process and full IHTA mechanics are detailed in Section 7.

6.4 What Stage 3 explicitly does not do

Stage 3 is bounded. It does not address the following matters, which are referred to the successor framework:

- Comprehensive ballistic-missile architecture (referred to a regional dialogue under the Crescent Compact Part VIII or RAMES regional security architecture).
- Israel-Lebanon-Hezbollah final-status terms (referred to Crescent Compact Part II).
- Israeli-Palestinian political settlement (excluded entirely; no party to this Accord is a party to that question).
- Saudi-Israeli normalization (referred to Crescent Compact Part IV; not bundled).
- Houthi political integration in Yemen (referred to RAMES Annex N or successor).
- Syria reconstruction (referred to Crescent Compact Part VII).
- Iraq militia integration (referred to RCSA Sub-State Authority modules).

This bounded scope is the Accord's primary virtue. By refusing to be a comprehensive treaty, it avoids the comprehensive treaty's failure mode: collapse under the weight of every regional issue brought into a single instrument.

Section 7 — The Hormuz Mechanism: A Joint Maritime Authority

The single most important institutional element of this Accord is the Joint Hormuz Authority — in its provisional Stage 1–2 form, and in its permanent Stage 3 form as the International Hormuz Transit Authority (IHTA). The Hormuz mechanism is what allows both sides to characterize the outcome as a sovereign win. The United States gets institutionalized freedom of navigation; Iran gets a permanent governance seat replacing US unilateralism; the Gulf states get stability; the global energy market gets predictability.

7.1 Why this configuration works for both sides

For the United States. Freedom of navigation is institutionalized in international treaty law, with the United States holding a permanent voting seat on the governing council. Iran can no longer unilaterally close the Strait. Iranian harassment of US-affiliated vessels becomes a treaty violation triggering immediate Council session, not a bilateral dispute. The US Fifth Fleet retains operational presence and force-protection authority. Project Freedom is characterized as having succeeded in opening the Strait under multilateral terms.

For Iran. Iran holds a permanent governance seat with chair authority on alternating years. Hormuz revenues fund Iranian civilian reconstruction at approximately \$200 million per year, framed and audited as Iranian sovereign property. The unilateral US Fifth Fleet enforcement authority is replaced by joint authority with formal Iranian co-equality. Iranian territorial waters remain Iranian; no UNCLOS sovereignty waiver is required. The Strait is explicitly characterized in the IHTA Charter as a multilateral commons, not a US-controlled passage.

For the Gulf states. Predictable transit. Reduced premium for shipping insurance. Direct seat on the Council through the GCC rotating chair (Oman, Qatar, UAE). End to the perpetual cycle of US-Iran near-conflict that has driven volatility for two decades.

For global commerce. Predictable, rule-governed transit. A tolling structure that funds infrastructure, safety, and pollution response. A crisis hotline that reduces escalation from incidents.

7.2 IHTA Council composition

Member	Status	Role
Islamic Republic of Iran	Permanent voting member	Senior permanent seat reflecting territorial sovereignty over northern and eastern shores. Chair authority in alternating years.
United States of America	Permanent voting member	Permanent seat reflecting principal maritime security provider role. Co-chair authority in alternating years.
GCC Rotating Chair	Permanent voting member	Single seat rotating annually among Oman, Qatar, and UAE. Reflects Gulf state economic interest. Tie-breaking authority on enforcement matters where US and Iran disagree.
European Union	Observer (speaking rights, no vote)	Major energy consumer. Chairs Environmental and Safety Subcommittee.
People's Republic of China	Observer (speaking rights, no vote)	Largest single Gulf-oil importer. Technical observer. Activated in Stage 3.
UN Secretary-General's Appointee	Neutral chair (non-voting; tie-breaking on procedural matters)	Appointed from standing pool: Switzerland, Singapore, Brazil, Sweden, Oman. Either Iran or the US may strike one candidate per cycle.
Iraq	Conditional observer	Observer when issues directly affect Iraqi maritime exports.
India	Conditional observer	Observer when issues directly affect Indian energy imports. Technical participation rights.

7.3 Decision rules

- **Routine operational decisions** (tolling rate adjustments within the inflation-plus-2% annual cap, safety protocols, maintenance scheduling): weighted majority of permanent voting members (any 2 of 3 agree).
- **Enforcement actions affecting Iranian-flagged vessels:** requires Iranian concurrence or neutral chair casting vote.
- **Enforcement actions against all other vessels:** consensus-minus-one (either Iran or US may object; GCC chair resolves with neutral chair).
- **Structural changes to tolling architecture or governance:** unanimous permanent member consent plus 90-day notice.
- **Emergency enforcement actions in imminent threat scenarios:** 24-hour mandatory consultation via de-escalation hotline; narrowly tailored temporary enforcement permitted with 24-hour post-hoc notification to Council. No principal party may unreasonably withhold concurrence where credible, time-sensitive threats are verified.

7.4 Tolling architecture

Tier	Vessel category	Rate	Clearance
1	Humanitarian essential (medicine, food, medical equipment)	Zero	24-hour fast-track
2	Standard commercial (general cargo, container, bulk)	\$0.15/ton	48-hour standard
3	Energy/premium (oil tankers, LNG, chemicals)	\$0.25/ton or \$35,000 flat for VLCC	Standard with surcharge structure

Tolls are formally designated as *Navigation Service Charges* — a standard designation in international maritime frameworks for operational cost-recovery, not a political levy on a global chokepoint. Rate adjustments are capped at inflation plus 2 percent annually. Structural changes require 90-day advance notice. Charges do not apply to military vessels of member states.

7.5 Revenue allocation

Annual revenue is estimated at approximately \$500 million, allocated as follows:

Allocation	Percentage	Annual estimate	Use
Iranian Civilian Reconstruction Fund	40%	≈\$200M	Repair of infrastructure damaged in Operation Epic Fury. Administered by IHTA with World Bank trustee oversight; EITI-published quarterly. Iran controls reconstruction priorities; IHTA controls fiduciary process.
International Maritime Safety Fund	35%	≈\$175M	Joint hotline operations, coast-guard coordination, pollution response, navigational safety, mine clearance reserve.
IHTA Operations and Reserve	25%	≈\$125M	Headquarters operations (Muscat), staff salaries, technology infrastructure. Capped at 24 months operating costs; surplus redirected to Reconstruction Fund.

7.6 Jurisdiction definition

The IHTA's jurisdiction is precisely defined as the maritime area bounded by: (a) the outer limit of the Iranian territorial sea (12 nautical miles from the baselines of the Iranian mainland and islands) on the northern and eastern boundaries; (b) the outer limit of the Omani territorial sea on the southern boundary; and (c) a line connecting Ras al-Hadd, Oman to the Iranian coast at 25°40' N, 57°20' E on the eastern boundary.

Within this defined international waters corridor, the IHTA exercises tolling authority. The IHTA has no tolling authority within the 12-nautical-mile territorial waters of any littoral state. Vessels transiting exclusively through territorial waters without entering the defined IHTA corridor are not subject to IHTA

tolls.

7.7 Maritime de-escalation protocols

- **Maritime incident hotline.** 24/7 Omani-hosted hotline linking IRGC-Navy, US Fifth Fleet, Iranian Navy, and JHA Maritime Coordination Cell. 2-hour mandatory response window.
- **Vessel harassment parameters.** Defined as: approach within 100 meters at speed; illumination of vessel with targeting radar; simulated attack maneuvers. Any harassment incident triggers immediate hotline and 24-hour JIG notification.
- **No-seizure zone.** Commercial vessels in international waters of the IHTA corridor may not be seized by any party without prior JHA notification and attribution process.
- **Agreed transit lane separation.** Three lanes separated by 5-nautical-mile buffers (Lane 1 northbound near Iranian coast; Lane 2 center neutral; Lane 3 southbound near Omani coast). Speed limit 15 knots in the Strait proper.
- **Mine prohibition.** Any detected naval mine in the IHTA corridor triggers automatic UN Security Council emergency session and automatic JIG material-breach review.
- **Carrier transit notification.** US carrier-group transits of the IHTA corridor occur only during pre-announced 48-hour windows. Iranian Navy may observe from beyond 20 nm but may not intercept, shadow closely, or simulate attack runs.
- **Toll-evasion enforcement.** Vessels refusing to pay IHTA tolls are denied port access in framework-compliant states until paid; international maritime liens may be registered with IMO. Kinetic interception for toll enforcement is explicitly prohibited.

Section 8 — What the United States Wins

The Accord delivers a deliverable, defensible set of wins for the United States that can be communicated within a single political news cycle and sustained through the November midterm election. The wins are intentionally calibrated to be publicly demonstrable rather than technically maximal.

8.1 Headline wins

Strait of Hormuz reopened. Within 7 days of signature. Verified by Lloyd's List vessel transit data, UN OCHA confirmation, and JHA observation. The single most impactful economic deliverable: 20 percent of global oil and gas supply restored to predictable transit. Gas-pump prices begin to fall within weeks.

Project Freedom characterized as having succeeded. Project Freedom escort assets transition to JHA convoy support, and the President can credibly claim that the announced operation achieved its stated objective: opening the Strait. The transition occurs without an Iranian-American kinetic exchange and without losing US naval positioning.

Freedom of navigation institutionalized in international law. The IHTA Charter formally guarantees freedom of transit through the Strait of Hormuz under international treaty. Iran cannot unilaterally close the Strait without committing a treaty violation triggering automatic UNSC and JIG sessions. This is a permanent legal architecture, not a political concession that can be reversed.

Verified nuclear non-advancement standstill. Iran commits, in writing and verifiably, to not increase enrichment levels, not move enriched uranium from monitored sites, not resume activity at struck sites. This preserves the post-strike status quo, which represents a substantial setback to Iran's nuclear infrastructure relative to pre-war baseline. The Trump administration can credibly characterize this as having frozen Iran's nuclear program at its current degraded state.

End to maritime crisis without further military commitment. No new US military deployment required. No additional appropriation required. No US troop casualties associated with re-engagement. The naval blockade lifted, but Iranian ports' compliance with sanctions enforcement continues through the framework's pre-cleared transaction corridors.

Bipartisan domestic political defensibility. Asset return is structured as Iranian sovereign property restitution, not as US expenditure. Sanctions relief is phased and conditional. Each major asset tranche after the pilot is subject to Congressional review window. Snapback authority is preserved with narrowly-defined material-breach triggers.

Israeli security backstop preserved. Iran's enrichment is verified to be non-advancing. The Lebanon track is separated. Israeli intelligence operations and self-defense rights are unaffected by the Accord. Israel retains observer status on Iran-related JIG matters.

No basing concessions; no force-posture concessions. US bases in the Gulf remain. US treaty obligations to GCC partners remain. No troop withdrawals required. The only US force-posture adjustment is conversion of Project Freedom escort to JHA convoy support, which is itself characterizable as a US-led

multilateral framework.

8.2 Domestic political messaging architecture

The Accord is designed to be communicable within the constraints of US domestic politics. The recommended public framing for the Trump administration is:

"We forced Iran to open Hormuz, freeze its nuclear program, and accept international oversight. We're getting their assets returned in tranches with Congressional review at every step. We didn't give up a single base. American forces did not leave the region. And we did it without losing another American life."

Each clause of this framing maps to a specific Accord deliverable that is verifiable in the Public Wins Ledger maintained by the JHA secretariat. None of the framing requires characterizing Iran's actions as anything other than reciprocal sovereign decisions.

8.3 What the US explicitly does not get

- Comprehensive nuclear dismantlement (deferred to Stage 3 MOU and successor framework).
- Elimination of Iran's ballistic-missile program (referred to regional architecture).
- Hezbollah disarmament (referred to Crescent Compact Lebanon track).
- Iranian recognition of Israel (not in scope).
- Iranian regime change (explicitly precluded by non-interference commitment in successor framework, but not by this Accord).

These deferrals are not concessions; they are the price of getting Stage 1 closed in 14 days rather than collapsing into renewed warfare. They are explicitly addressed in the successor framework architecture.

Section 9 — What Iran Wins

The Accord delivers a defensible set of wins that the Mojtaba Khamenei succession can present as a sovereign vindication and that the IRGC, the Guardian Council, the Assembly of Experts, and the Iranian parliament can ratify without constitutional crisis. The wins are calibrated to be sovereign in framing and tangible in substance.

9.1 Headline wins

Permanent end to active hostilities. The bilateral war is ended within 14 days of signature, under terms registered with the United Nations and witnessed by Pakistan, Oman, and Switzerland. Iran can credibly claim it has terminated the war Israel and the United States started, on terms Iran accepted as sovereign reciprocal commitments.

US naval blockade lifted. The US naval blockade on Iranian commercial ports — imposed April 13, 2026 — is lifted on Day 7 of the Accord. Iranian ports return to commercial operation. This is a visible, verifiable US concession on a measure Iran has publicly characterized as wartime aggression.

Project Freedom unilateral escort terminated. The unilateral US Navy escort operation announced May 3 is suspended on Accord signature and replaced by joint multilateral authority. Iran can credibly characterize this as the United States relinquishing its claim to unilateral enforcement in the Strait.

Permanent governance seat on the IHTA. Iran holds a permanent voting seat on the International Hormuz Transit Authority Council, with chair authority on alternating years. The unilateral US-led order in the Strait is replaced with formal Iranian co-equality.

\$200 million per year in Hormuz toll revenue. The Iranian Civilian Reconstruction Fund receives 40 percent of IHTA revenues — approximately \$200 million annually — earmarked for repair of war damage. Audited by World Bank trustee; Iran controls reconstruction priorities.

Return of frozen sovereign assets in staged tranches. Approximately \$100 billion in frozen Iranian sovereign assets returned in staged tranches. Day 1 pilot of \$250 million; cumulative 50 percent by Day 60; cumulative 85 percent by Day 180. The pilot and first two tranches are explicitly non-reversible.

Sanctions relief on humanitarian, aviation, and consumer sectors immediately. Day 1 humanitarian relief is unconditional. Day 14 banking channels for humanitarian trade. Day 30 aviation safety parts for Iran Air. Day 60 SWIFT reconnection process. Stage 3 brings deeper relief on petrochemicals, oil services, and broader banking.

Nuclear file deferred to Stage 3 under sovereign framing. The 9-point US demand for upfront enrichment restrictions is dropped. The nuclear standstill is preservation of post-strike status quo, characterized as Iran's sovereign choice not to escalate during a wartime pause. NPT rights explicitly preserved. Any future restrictions framed as reciprocal sovereign commitments, not imposed restrictions.

Recognition as a major regional power. Iran's permanent IHTA seat, recognition in the Accord text as the principal sovereign power on the northern Strait, and the framing of Iran's commitments as sovereign reciprocal acts collectively constitute formal acknowledgment of Iran as a co-equal regional power.

No basing concessions required. Iran is not required to accept US bases on its territory or to permit US military operations in its airspace. The non-interference commitment in the successor framework will explicitly prohibit US covert action and regime-change operations.

Constitutional governance preserved. The Accord places no requirement on Iranian internal governance. The Guardian Council, Assembly of Experts, and constitutional processes are explicitly preserved. The Mojtaba Khamenei succession is unaffected.

9.2 Domestic political messaging architecture

The recommended public framing for the Iranian government is:

"We have ended the war the United States and Israel started against us. American naval forces have lifted their blockade of our ports. Iran's permanent seat on the new Hormuz Authority replaces decades of American unilateralism. Our frozen sovereign property is returning to the Iranian nation. We have not surrendered a single sovereign right. Our nuclear program remains under Iranian sovereign authority, and the United States has accepted that any future discussions will be on the basis of reciprocal sovereign commitments, not imposition."

Each clause maps to a specific Accord deliverable. None requires the Iranian government to characterize its commitments as concessions, capitulations, or U-turns.

9.3 Hardliner management

Critical to the Accord's Iranian survivability is endorsement by the IRGC, the Mojtaba Khamenei succession, and the senior clerical establishment. The following architectural elements are designed to facilitate that endorsement:

- The Accord uses the language of "sovereign reciprocal commitments" throughout. No clause requires Iran to acknowledge defeat or accept US conditions.
- The IRGC Navy retains operational authority in Iranian territorial waters. JHA jurisdiction is restricted to international waters of the IHTA corridor. Iranian small-craft patrols continue (with the 5-nautical-mile separation from the central transit corridor).
- Iran retains all NPT rights. The standstill is preservation of status quo, not rollback. No enrichment commitment is required during Stage 1 or Stage 2.
- Iran's missile program is not addressed in this Accord (referred to regional dialogue). This is a major Iranian win.
- Asset return is framed as restitution of Iranian sovereign property — not as US payment, US reparation, or US concession. The framing is essential.

- Hormuz toll revenue is Iranian property: 40 percent of IHTA revenues flow to the Iranian Civilian Reconstruction Fund, audited transparently but under Iranian programmatic control.
- The Lebanon track is separated. Iran is not required to deliver Hezbollah disarmament as a condition of the Accord — only an operational pause.
- Domestic Iranian narrative sovereignty is explicitly protected. The Iranian government may characterize Iranian commitments in any terms consistent with meeting objective benchmarks.

Section 10 — What the Region Wins

The Accord cannot be politically sustainable unless it is endorsed — or at minimum not actively opposed — by the major regional actors. The following is the Accord's calibration to regional interests.

10.1 Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates

The Gulf states have the largest direct stake in the Accord. The dual blockade has driven energy market volatility that has cost regional revenues directly and depressed sovereign investment programs (Saudi Vision 2030, UAE diversification). Reopening Hormuz is a primary Gulf-state interest. The GCC rotating chair (Oman, Qatar, or UAE — annually rotating) on the IHTA Council provides direct Gulf-state representation in governance.

The Accord does not require the Gulf states to normalize relations with Iran beyond what they have already initiated. It does not require Gulf-state disengagement from US security arrangements. It does not require Gulf-state acceptance of any specific Lebanon, Yemen, or Iraq settlement. The Gulf states get stability without being asked to make new concessions.

10.2 Israel

Israel is not a party to this Accord. Israel's interests are protected through three architectural elements: the verified nuclear standstill (Iran's enrichment is frozen at its post-strike degraded baseline); Iran's commitment to instruct Hezbollah on an operational pause; and the explicit preservation of Israeli intelligence operations and self-defense rights. Israel will be invited to permanent observer status on Iran-related JIG matters in Stage 3, consistent with the Crescent Compact architecture.

Israeli leadership is unlikely to publicly endorse this Accord because Israeli political constraints favor maximum-pressure framings. Israeli leadership is also unlikely to actively oppose the Accord because the alternative — resumed US-Iran warfare with Israeli direct involvement — is strategically more costly to Israel than a verified standstill at Iran's currently-degraded nuclear baseline. The Accord's design assumes Israeli quiet acquiescence, not Israeli endorsement.

10.3 Pakistan

Pakistan is the primary mediator and the country whose role this Accord most expands. Pakistan gains: a confirmed primary mediator role in a successful Middle East stabilization (diplomatic prestige); standing Pakistani Army Chief and Prime Minister's Office channels to both Tehran and Washington; potential access to GCC reconstruction financing as a stability broker; and a strengthened position in its own bilateral relationships with the United States, China, and the Gulf states.

10.4 Oman

Oman hosts the IHTA secretariat in Muscat and the Maritime Coordination Cell in Khasab. Oman becomes the operational hub of the post-conflict Gulf maritime regime — extending its decades-long role as the back-channel between Tehran and Washington into a formal institutional position. Oman's strategic significance and revenue base both expand.

10.5 Iraq

Iraq gains a stable Gulf-export environment for its oil revenues, observer status on the IHTA Council when Iraqi maritime exports are directly affected, and an end to the cross-border instability that flows from US-Iran tension. Iraq's complex internal politics — including the PMF-state relationship — is not addressed by this Accord but becomes more tractable in a post-war environment.

10.6 China and India

Both are major energy importers and both are technical observers on the IHTA Council. Each gains predictable Gulf energy supply. China specifically gains a documented role in a US-orchestrated Middle East stabilization — a strategic prestige gain. India gains predictable supply for its growing energy demand and the stability that supports Indian shipping interests.

10.7 The European Union

The EU gains observer status on the IHTA Council and chairs the Environmental and Safety Subcommittee. The EU's parallel sanctions regime aligns with US relief tranches under the framework, restoring European commercial access to Iran consistent with US authorization. The EU's role in maintaining the Accord through the Stage 3 successor framework will be expanded through the JIG architecture.

10.8 Lebanon, Yemen, and Syria

These conflicts are not within the Accord's scope. They are referred to the Crescent Compact and RAMES architectures for separate negotiation. The Accord's success creates conditions in which those tracks become more tractable; its failure does not preclude their progress.

Section 11 — Sequencing Matrix and Reciprocal Movement

The Accord's sequencing follows what the source frameworks call the *Waltz Philosophy* of synchronized reciprocal motion: each commitment by one party is matched by a corresponding commitment by the other; neither party is exposed to defection; verification is shared. The following matrix specifies the exact sequencing for the first 90 days.

Day	United States moves	Iran moves	Verification
1	Suspends Project Freedom; ceases offensive operations; issues OFAC license for \$250M pilot transfer; confirms nuclear deferral and standstill arrangement.	Ceases offensive operations; transmits Hezbollah operational pause; transmits Houthi Red Sea pause.	Pakistan PM Office + UN Special Envoy + Oman + Switzerland concurrent.
3	Maintains ceasefire; OFAC humanitarian license issued.	First humanitarian-flagged vessel cleared for Hormuz transit.	Lloyd's List + UN OCHA + JHA observation post Khasab.
7	Lifts naval blockade on Iranian commercial ports; transitions Project Freedom assets to JHA convoy support.	Opens Hormuz to all commercial transit; withdraws IRGC small craft from central corridor; commences mine-clearing.	JHA observation vessels (US, Iran, Oman flagged); Lloyd's List; UN OCHA.
14	Stage 1 closing certification.	Stage 1 closing certification.	Pakistan + Oman + Switzerland concurrent; transition to Stage 2 automatic.
20	Welcomes IAEA redeployment.	Issues invitation to IAEA inspectors for declared sites; standstill verified.	IAEA Director General confirms; satellite imagery and national technical means corroborate.
30	OFAC issues licenses for aviation safety parts (Boeing/Airbus) and specialty exports; first sanctions tranche operative; OFAC processes second asset tranche transfer.	Confirms receipt of asset tranche; maintains Hormuz operations; standstill maintained.	JIG verification; 30-day Congressional review window.
45	Confirms transition of provisional JHA to operating mode.	Confirms IHTA Tier 1 and Tier 2 tolling operative.	JHA Council unanimous certification.
60	Processes third asset tranche; first sanctions tranche fully operational; SWIFT reconnection process commenced for FATF-compliant Iranian banks.	Stage 2 closing certification; Hormuz Tier 3 tolling operative; standstill maintained.	JIG closing certification; transition to Stage 3 automatic.
75	Opens nuclear MOU framework negotiation.	Confirms willingness to engage; standstill maintained; IAEA cooperation continues.	JIG facilitation; bilateral negotiating teams convene.

Day	United States moves	Iran moves	Verification
90	Confirms permanent IHTA conversion; UN appointment of neutral chair.	Confirms permanent IHTA conversion.	UN Secretary-General + JIG unanimous certification.

11.1 The principle: neither side moves alone

Each Iranian commitment in the matrix is matched by a corresponding US commitment within the same day or the next sequential day. Neither side is required to make a unilateral move dependent on the other side's good faith. Each side's compliance is verified by neutral parties before the next reciprocal movement is triggered.

This is the structural foundation of the Accord's political viability. The Iranian government can defend the sequencing as Iran responding only when the United States has moved first or moved simultaneously. The US administration can defend the sequencing as the US moving only when Iran has moved first or moved simultaneously. Both characterizations are factually correct.

11.2 Asymmetric reversibility

One asymmetry is deliberately built into the Accord. Iran's Stage 1 operational concessions (Hormuz reopening, blockade-corresponding concessions, mine-clearing, IRGC withdrawal from the central corridor) are operationally irreversible upon execution. The first 50 percent of asset tranches transferred to Iran are similarly irreversible upon transfer. This asymmetry matches operational reality with financial reality: where Iran cannot easily walk back the physical concession, the US cannot easily walk back the financial commitment.

Stage 2 and Stage 3 deliverables are subject to the snapback friction ladder defined in Section 14 (no instant reversal; minimum 150-day reimposition window for any sanctions snapback; 30-day Congressional notification; JIG material-breach determination required).

Section 12 — Verification, Monitoring, and Compliance

Verification is the spine of the Accord. The architecture follows the multi-source resilience principle from RAMES and the Crescent Compact: no single verification channel can either trigger or block compliance determinations on its own. Every material finding requires convergent evidence from at least two independent channels.

12.1 The five verification channels

Channel	Operates	Coverage
Pakistani Mediator Channel	Throughout	Bilateral diplomatic channel; ceasefire compliance; major commitment certification.
Omani Technical Channel	Throughout	Maritime operations; JHA observation; hotline operations; mine clearance coordination.
Swiss Financial Channel	Throughout	Asset transfer verification; sanctions relief implementation; banking reconnection.
IAEA	From Day 20	Nuclear standstill verification at declared sites; environmental sampling; technical reporting.
National Technical Means	Throughout (no Accord constraint)	Satellite imagery, signals intelligence, all national capabilities. Used as backstop and as discrepancy detector.

12.2 The Joint Implementation Group (JIG)

The JIG is the central coordination body for Stages 2 and 3. It is hosted in Geneva. Its membership is: United States, Iran, Pakistan, Oman, Switzerland, EU observer, UN Special Envoy. People's Republic of China and a GCC rotating chair join as observers in Stage 3.

The JIG meets in plenary every 30 days during Stages 2 and 3, with technical working groups in continuous session. JIG decisions on material-breach determinations require majority of permanent members (US, Iran, Pakistan, Oman, Switzerland), with Pakistan as facilitating chair. JIG operates under what the source frameworks call *consensus-minus-one* for non-breach matters: any single permanent member can object, but objection triggers extended deliberation rather than immediate failure.

12.3 Public Wins Ledger

The JIG secretariat publishes a continuously updated Public Wins Ledger, accessible to domestic audiences in all participating states via a publicly available web portal in English, Farsi, Arabic, French, Spanish, Russian, Chinese, and Hebrew. The Ledger documents, per party: verified benefits delivered; verified obligations fulfilled; cumulative compliance score. Updated within 48 hours of any verified milestone completion.

The Public Wins Ledger gives every leader a real-time, JIG-certified answer to *"what have we actually gotten from this?"* — framed in domestically accessible language for each party's audience. Critically, the Ledger is symmetric: every party's wins are documented, not just one. No party's concessions appear on

another party's wins page without also appearing as a sovereign action on the conceding party's own page. This turns compliance into ongoing domestic political capital rather than a technical compliance burden.

12.4 Discrepancy resolution

Where verification channels report inconsistent findings — for example, where IAEA reporting and US national technical means diverge on a nuclear-standstill question — the JIG convenes a Technical Discrepancy Panel within 72 hours. The Panel includes representatives of each reporting channel and a neutral technical expert from a standing roster (rotating among Switzerland, Brazil, Sweden, Singapore, Oman). Panel findings are advisory; the JIG retains final authority.

If the Discrepancy Panel cannot reach consensus within 14 days, the matter is escalated to the JIG for political resolution. During the discrepancy review, no party may take unilateral action based on its preferred reading of the disputed evidence. Stabilization Hold rules (see Section 14) apply.

Section 13 — De-Escalation Protocols and Crisis Management

The Accord operates in an environment where incidents will occur. Vessels will collide. Drones will deviate. Personnel will misread orders. Third parties — Houthi splinters, ISIS remnants, Israeli operations, Saudi-Iran tensions — will create incidents that one or both parties may misattribute. The Accord's survivability depends entirely on its ability to absorb such incidents without collapsing back into open warfare.

13.1 Five independent de-escalation pathways

The Accord adopts the five-pathway architecture from RAMES Point 13. Each pathway operates independently; failure of any one does not prevent the others from functioning.

Pathway	Activation trigger	Maximum duration
Crisis Lock	10+ party-national fatalities; verified direct military clash; critical infrastructure attack; IAEA integrity alert	14 days; extendable to 42 by JIG majority
Third-Party Spoiler Attribution Protocol (TSAP)	Third-party attack or spoiler activity; attribution panel determines sponsorship before any bilateral penalty applies	30-day investigation window; non-attributable classification = no penalties
Military Deconfliction Hotline	Any military incident	Permanent 24/7 operation
Regional Incident Firewall	Third-party regional escalation threatening framework	Immediate JIG notification within 4 hours; bilateral consultation within 24
Direct Executive Link	Imminent crisis requiring head-of-state communication	Pre-established secure channel; 6-hour consultation capability

13.2 The 24-hour cooling-off rule

Adopted from the Emergency Extension Plan: when an incident occurs, no escalatory action by either party may be taken within the first 24 hours of the incident. The 24-hour window is used for Pakistani guarantor backchannel review, fact-gathering by JHA observation assets, and discrepancy assessment. The rule is enforced through pre-commitment: both governments have authorized in advance that the first 24 hours after any incident is a fact-finding window, not a response window.

The 24-hour cooling-off does not apply where an active armed attack is in progress; self-defense rights are preserved. It applies to retaliatory or punitive responses to completed incidents, where the strategic question is whether to escalate, not whether to defend.

13.3 Third-party non-attribution buffer

When an incident occurs that may be attributable to a third party (Houthi splinter, ISIS remnant, Israeli operation, Saudi-Iranian incident, criminal action, accident), the TSAP convenes within 72 hours to classify the incident into one of four categories: state-sponsored; proxy with state backing; independent non-state actor; inconclusive. Default rule: if investigation remains inconclusive after 10 days, the incident is classified Non-Attributable. No bilateral penalty applies. Response is limited to cooperative threat mitigation.

This is critical. Historical analysis of treaty collapse shows that frameworks fail not from deliberate policy reversal but from a single ambiguous incident that neither side has adequate institutional tools to manage. The non-attribution buffer prevents exploitation of ambiguity to trigger escalation.

13.4 Stabilization Holds

Adopted from the CRSF v4.3 architecture and incorporated into the Crescent Compact: when a specific Accord measure becomes domestically untenable in either capital, that measure can be placed on Stabilization Hold for up to 90 days. During the Hold:

- All other Accord obligations remain in force.
- After 90 days in Hold, the contested measure freezes but the freeze itself does not constitute a violation (Minimal Compliance Mode).
- The stabilization continues; only the contested measure is paused.
- This prevents a single blocked issue from collapsing the entire framework.

Stabilization Holds permit governments to tell domestic constituencies: *"We are pausing this measure pending review"* without breach. They are politically essential.

Section 14 — Snapback, Withdrawal, and Reversibility

Both governments require that the Accord preserve the option of exit. Neither will commit to an instrument that locks in obligations under all conditions. The snapback architecture is calibrated to be slow enough to allow dispute resolution and prevent accidental collapse, but automatic enough to be a credible deterrent.

14.1 Snapback friction ladder

Adopted from RAMES v9.1 and the CBSF snapback architecture, with adjustments for the wartime configuration:

Step	Threshold	Authorization required	Effect
1 — Advisory Notice	Verified compliance anomaly; Weighted Breach Index (WBI) score 5+	JIG notification only — no vote	Enhanced monitoring; advancement frozen; formal notice to responsible party.
2 — Partial Restriction	WBI 8+; or 2 minor + 1 major breach; or Pattern of Concern designation	JIG majority vote	Targeted sector restrictions; new banking tier review; published JIG determination.
3 — Emergency Fast-Track	Clearly defined material breach under Annex F; or WBI 12+	JIG 2/3 supermajority vote; or Presidential certification to Congress with 48-hour notice	Full snapback consideration; asset freeze reversal subject to non-reversibility protections; minimum 150-day implementation window.

14.2 Sanctions inertia buffer

Reimposition of sanctions requires: JIG material-breach determination (30 days) plus commercial wind-down notice (60 days) plus banking implementation (60 days) — minimum 150 days from determination to full reimposition. Emergency fast-track is available for clearly defined material breach events only, and requires Presidential certification to Congress with 48-hour notice.

14.3 Asset return non-reversibility

The pilot asset transfer (Day 1, \$250M) and the first two tranches (Day 30, Day 60; cumulative 50 percent) are explicitly non-reversible. They cannot be re-frozen by any Step of the snapback ladder. This is a major Iranian protection and is essential to making the asset return credible from the Iranian side.

Tranches 3 and 4 (Day 120, Day 180) and the Reserve (Day 365) are subject to snapback, but only with the 150-day inertia buffer. No instant clawback is possible.

14.4 Withdrawal-penalty escrow

Released asset funds are placed in protected accounts. If the United States reimposes sanctions outside the JIG process, Iran retains at least 50 percent of released funds plus penalty interest calculated at US Treasury rates plus 3 percentage points. This is a deterrent to capricious US reversal, drawn from the Crescent Compact escrow architecture.

14.5 Graduated exit

Either party may exercise *partial withdrawal* — suspending some obligations while maintaining core commitments — or *full withdrawal* — complete exit. Re-entry rights are preserved within 24 months of partial withdrawal or 12 months of full withdrawal. This graduated exit architecture, drawn from CBSF v15, prevents an all-or-nothing dynamic in which any complaint becomes a withdrawal threat.

Section 15 — Domestic Political Architecture

The Accord is engineered for domestic political survivability in both capitals. The following elements are designed to address the specific political constraints in each system.

15.1 United States political architecture

Bipartisan Quorum Engineering. Prior to each major phase transition announcement, the JIG secretariat provides embargoed briefings to designated members of both parties on the Senate Foreign Relations Committee and House Foreign Affairs Committee. Briefings are simultaneous, identical, and non-partisan in framing. Members are invited to associate themselves with framework milestones before public announcement.

Economic District Mapping. Implementation benefits — aviation safety parts contracts, agricultural exports, port reopening, energy market stabilization — are mapped to economic districts represented by persuadable members of both parties. The distribution ensures that no party can characterize the Accord as purely benefiting the other party's constituency.

Congressional Review Windows. Each asset tranche after the pilot is subject to a 30-day Congressional review window. Release proceeds unless Congress enacts a resolution of disapproval within the review window. This preserves Congressional oversight without requiring affirmative Senate action for each tranche.

Red Line Consultation. Before each major escalation threshold decision (Step 3 of the snapback ladder), the executive branch consults with the chairs and ranking members of the four key committees. This creates co-ownership of enforcement decisions and prevents "soft on violations" attacks.

Trump Administration Framing. Internal guidance: the Accord is framed as "maximum pressure delivered" — the war ended on US terms, Iran's nuclear program frozen at its degraded post-strike state, US bases preserved, US blockade lifted only after Iranian Hormuz reopening. Not as a JCPOA return; not as a concession. The talking point is: "We forced them open, and we got our assets back."

Israel relationship management. Joint pre-announcement coordination with the Israeli Prime Minister's office 48 hours before public announcement. Israeli observer status on Iran-related JIG matters in Stage 3. Israeli intelligence operations and self-defense rights explicitly preserved. Lebanon track separated.

15.2 Iranian political architecture

Mojtaba Khamenei succession protection. The Accord places no requirement on Iranian internal governance. The Mojtaba Khamenei succession is unaffected. The Guardian Council's authority is unaffected. The Assembly of Experts retains full constitutional authority. The Accord neither legitimizes nor delegitimizes the succession; it is structurally agnostic.

IRGC operational authority preserved. IRGC retains operational authority in Iranian territorial waters. JHA jurisdiction is restricted to international waters. IRGC small-craft patrols continue (with the 5 nm separation requirement from the central transit corridor). IRGC budget and personnel are not affected by the Accord.

Sovereign framing protected. The Accord text uses sovereign reciprocal-commitment language throughout. Domestic Iranian narrative sovereignty is explicitly protected. The Iranian government may characterize Iranian commitments in any terms consistent with meeting objective benchmarks. The US is precluded from characterizing Iranian commitments as capitulation.

Parliamentary involvement. The Accord may be ratified by the Iranian parliament under existing constitutional procedures. The Mojtaba Khamenei succession is invited to support ratification but is not required to. Parliamentary deferral of the proposed 12-point Hormuz statute is requested only for the Stage 1 period; the parliament retains full authority to legislate consistent with the Accord in subsequent stages.

Religious authority management. Senior clerical consultations on the Accord text are facilitated through the Pakistani channel. The Accord's framing as a sovereign reciprocal commitment, with NPT rights preserved and constitutional governance unaffected, is designed to be defensible under Shia jurisprudence. Senior clerical endorsement is sought but not required.

Asset return as restitution. All asset transfers are framed as return of Iranian sovereign property — not as US payment, not as concession, not as compensation. The framing is essential and is reinforced through legal characterization in IMF and World Bank registration.

15.3 Joint Communication Windows

For major milestones (Stage transitions, asset tranche releases, Hormuz reopening, IHTA activation), the JIG coordinates Joint Communication Windows: pre-agreed 48-hour periods in which all parties publish their milestone narratives simultaneously, preventing any single party's framing from dominating the initial news cycle. The Authorized Terminology Registry governs factual claims; each government retains political-interpretation sovereignty within its own narrative.

This structure allows the Trump administration to claim it forced Iran to open Hormuz while Tehran simultaneously announces that it ended the US war and reclaimed its sovereign property. Both narratives are factually consistent with the Accord; both are politically true.

Section 16 — Implementation Roadmap and Operational Costs

16.1 T-minus 5 days (pre-signature)

- Pakistan formally mediates acceptance of the Accord by both governments (confidential, not public initially).
- UN Security Council issues non-binding statement supporting Hormuz reopening and JHA activation.
- JIG core diplomatic tier is appointed and briefed.
- Three-channel notification system (Pakistan + Oman + Switzerland) is tested and confirmed operational.
- JHA Maritime Coordination Cell is staffed in Muscat (Oman provides hosting and security).
- OFAC general license texts for Day 1 humanitarian relief and pilot asset transfer are pre-cleared.
- Iranian Central Bank confirms readiness to receive pilot transfer.
- Israeli Prime Minister's office briefed by US administration; pre-announcement coordination confirmed.

16.2 Implementation tempo

Period	Operational tempo
Day 1	Signature; ceasefire on all fronts; pilot \$250M transfer; Project Freedom suspended; OFAC humanitarian license; first JHA Council session in Muscat.
Days 2–6	Hormuz operational protocols finalized; JHA observation vessels deployed; US-Iran-Oman hotline live-tested; first humanitarian transit (Day 3); IAEA pre-deployment coordination.
Days 7–14	Synchronized lift; first commercial transits; mine clearance commences; daily JHA transit reports published; Stage 1 closing certification on Day 14.
Days 15–60	Stage 2: JIG inaugurated (Day 15); IAEA redeployment (Day 20); first asset tranche (Day 30); first sanctions tranche (Day 30); JHA tolling operative (Day 45); second asset tranche (Day 60).
Days 61–180	Stage 3: Nuclear MOU framework (Day 75); permanent IHTA conversion (Day 90); third asset tranche (Day 120); 123 Agreement negotiation commenced (Day 150); fourth asset tranche and successor framework opened (Day 180).

16.3 Personnel and infrastructure

Drawing from the Emergency Extension Plan cost architecture, scaled for the larger Accord scope:

Element	Personnel	Annual cost
JIG Secretariat (Geneva)	12 FTE	\$3.5M
JHA / IHTA Headquarters (Muscat)	25 FTE	\$8.0M

Element	Personnel	Annual cost
JHA Maritime Coordination Cell (Khasab)	15 FTE + rotating maritime observers	\$5.5M
Pakistani Mediation Channel	8 FTE	\$1.8M
Swiss Financial Channel	6 FTE	\$1.6M
IAEA augmentation	8 FTE inspectors + 4 technical analysts	\$3.5M
Public Wins Ledger and translation	5 FTE + translation services	\$1.2M
Operations and infrastructure	Equipment, secure communications, satellite imagery, contingency reserve	\$8.0M
TOTAL		≈\$33M annually

16.4 Funding mechanism

Operational costs are funded as follows: 25 percent of IHTA revenues are allocated to operations and reserve (approximately \$125M annually once IHTA is fully operational). For the Stage 1 and Stage 2 startup period, before IHTA tolling reaches full revenue, the UN Trust Fund for Preventive Action provides \$10M, with voluntary contributions from the EU, Switzerland, Norway, Canada, Japan, Saudi Arabia, and the UAE making up the balance. The United States and Iran do not contribute directly to operational costs (avoiding quid pro quo dynamics).

Section 17 — Why This Accord Can Work

The Accord's design is the answer to a single question: *what is the minimum coherent instrument that closes the active war within a politically defensible timeframe, while preserving each side's sovereign claims and creating durable institutional architecture for the deferred questions?* Eight features, drawn from the source frameworks and calibrated to the May 2026 configuration, make it work.

It defers what cannot be solved now and resolves what cannot wait.

The nuclear file is deferred at Iran's own suggestion to a stage where it can be addressed without wartime pressure. The Hormuz file is resolved first because reality has already placed it first — Project Freedom begins May 4, the dual blockade is active, the global energy market is paying the cost. Sequencing matches operational urgency.

It creates irreversible facts in Stage 1 before harder concessions are required.

By the end of Stage 1 (Day 14), Hormuz is open, the dual blockade is lifted, \$250M has been transferred to Iran, JHA is operating, and the war is over. These are facts, not promises. They cannot be rescinded. Subsequent stages build on them rather than relitigating them.

It provides each side with face-saving sovereign framing.

Every Iranian concession is structured as a sovereign reciprocal commitment, not a coerced concession. Every US concession is structured as a multilateralization or restitution, not a unilateral give-away. Both sides can communicate domestically without using language the other side prohibits.

It separates failure modes.

Failure on Lebanon does not collapse the Accord. Failure on the nuclear MOU does not unwind Stage 1 deliverables. Failure on a single asset tranche does not require renegotiating prior tranches. Each component is structured to fail without contagion.

It is built on synchronized reciprocal motion.

The Waltz Philosophy: neither party moves alone. Each commitment is matched by a corresponding commitment within the same day or the next sequential day. Verification is shared. No party is exposed to defection. Trust is not required; choreography is required.

It uses three-channel verification with no single point of failure.

Pakistan as primary mediator. Oman as technical channel. Switzerland as financial channel. IAEA as nuclear channel. National technical means as backstop. No single channel can either trigger or block compliance determinations on its own.

It includes pre-cleared face-saving exits.

Stabilization Holds permit either side to pause specific measures without breach. Graduated exit (partial or full withdrawal with re-entry rights) prevents all-or-nothing dynamics. The 24-hour cooling-off rule prevents reflexive escalation. The third-party non-attribution buffer prevents exploitation of ambiguity.

It is signable in days.

The Accord deliberately omits comprehensive elements that would require months of negotiation. Stage 1 deliverables are operationally executable within 14 days. Stage 2 within 60 days. Stage 3 within 180 days. The successor framework — for the comprehensive nuclear, missile, and regional architecture — is then built on the Accord's stable foundation.

17.1 What it is not, and why that is its strength

The Accord is not a comprehensive peace treaty. It does not resolve the nuclear file, the ballistic-missile file, the Lebanon file, the Yemen file, the Syrian file, the Iraqi file, or the Israeli-Palestinian file. It does not require Iranian recognition of Israel. It does not require US troop withdrawal. It does not require Hezbollah disarmament.

If it tried to do any of these things it would fail. The 9-point and 14-point proposals tried to do too many things at once and stalled. The 15-point March proposal tried even more and stalled. The 10-point April proposal tried to bundle regional architecture with bilateral ceasefire and stalled.

The Accord's bounded scope is precisely what allows it to close. Hormuz, blockades, assets, ceasefire — closed in 14 days. Sanctions tranches, IAEA redeployment, asset return — staged to 60 days. Permanent IHTA, nuclear MOU, successor framework — to 180 days. Everything beyond is referred to its proper instrument.

The Accord can work because it is the instrument that the present moment will accept. The comprehensive instruments that were not accepted are still on the table for the moment when they can be. The Accord exists to make that moment possible.

Appendix A — Side-by-Side: 9-Point vs. 14-Point vs. Hormuz First

The following table maps every substantive element of the US 9-point proposal and the Iran 14-point proposal against the corresponding treatment in this Accord. Where the Accord adopts an element substantially as proposed, that is noted. Where it modifies, defers, or refers an element, that is noted with the rationale.

Issue	US 9-Point	Iran 14-Point	Hormuz First Accord
Ceasefire duration	2 months	Permanent within 30 days	Permanent on Day 1; staged closure of war-fighting domain by Day 14.
Strait of Hormuz	Iranian unconditional reopening	New mechanism replacing US unilateralism	Joint Hormuz Authority on Day 1; provisional toll on Day 45; permanent IHTA on Day 90.
US naval blockade	Lifted in step with Hormuz	Lifted unconditionally	Lifted on Day 7 in synchronized motion with Iranian Hormuz reopening.
Project Freedom	Begins May 4 unilaterally	Categorically rejected	Suspended on signature; transitioned to JHA convoy support on Day 7. Characterized by US as having succeeded; characterized by Iran as having been replaced.
Iranian asset return	Phased, conditional	Released as restitution	Pilot \$250M Day 1; cumulative 50% Day 60; cumulative 70% Day 120; cumulative 85% Day 180. Pilot and first two tranches non-reversible.
Sanctions relief	Phased, tied to nuclear compliance	Lifted as part of war termination	Day 1 humanitarian (unconditional); Day 30 aviation/consumer; Day 60 SWIFT process; Day 120 petrochemicals; Day 180 broader. Tied to Accord-wide compliance, not nuclear specifically.
Nuclear file	Central; restrictions required up front	Deferred to later stage	Deferred to Stage 3 (Day 75) under verified non-advancement standstill. MOU framework, not full agreement, in this Accord. Comprehensive agreement to successor framework.
Enrichment	Restricted from Day 1	NPT rights preserved; not in scope	Standstill at current post-strike levels for Stages 1 and 2. Restrictions, if any, negotiated in Stage 3 MOU as sovereign reciprocal commitments.
Iran's 60% stockpile	Disposition required	Not addressed	Stage 3 MOU addresses; options include third-country custody, in-country dilution, or fuel assembly conversion.
IAEA	Enhanced monitoring required	Not addressed	Standard safeguards inspections at declared sites from Day 20. Challenge inspections suspended for Stages 1–2; resumed in Stage 3 if MOU includes.

Issue	US 9-Point	Iran 14-Point	Hormuz First Accord
US war reparations	Not in scope	Required	Not adopted as reparations. Replaced by: pilot transfer, asset tranches, Hormuz toll revenue (\$200M/year to Iranian Civilian Reconstruction Fund). Iran may characterize the package domestically; US does not characterize it as reparations.
US forces in region	Posture preserved	Withdrawal from Iran's periphery	No basing changes. Project Freedom transitioned to JHA. Carrier transit windows in Hormuz become declared and pre-notified rather than discretionary. No troop withdrawals.
Lebanon front	Hezbollah disarmament track	End all hostilities including Lebanon	Separated to parallel track. Iran commits to instructing Hezbollah operational pause; full Lebanese settlement referred to Crescent Compact Part II.
Houthi / Red Sea	Not specifically addressed	Not specifically addressed	Iran transmits Red Sea operational pause instruction to Houthi leadership on Day 1. Iranian-supplied weapons used against commercial shipping = material breach.
Ballistic missiles	Not in scope (regional)	Not in scope	Referred to regional dialogue under successor framework.
Israel	Coordination on Iran issues	Not addressed	Observer status on Iran-related JIG matters in Stage 3. Israeli intelligence and self-defense rights explicitly preserved. Lebanon track separated.
Iranian sovereignty	Not addressed	Central; non-interference required	Sovereign reciprocal-commitment framing throughout. Constitutional governance preserved. NPT rights preserved. Non-interference commitment in successor framework.
Mediator	Pakistan (with US/Iran direct)	Pakistan	Pakistan primary; Oman technical; Switzerland financial; UN observer; EU observer in JIG.
Closing instrument	Comprehensive ceasefire agreement	Three-stage peace plan	Three-stage Accord (14d / 60d / 180d) bridging to comprehensive successor framework (RCSA, Crescent Compact, RAMES).

Appendix B — Public Communication Templates

The following are pre-approved communication templates for both governments at each major milestone. Both governments retain narrative sovereignty within their domestic communication; the Authorized Terminology Registry governs only factual claims, not political interpretation.

B.1 Day 1 — Signature announcement

United States:

"Today the United States, working with Iran through Pakistani mediation, has secured an agreement that ends the war we were forced to fight. Within 14 days, the Strait of Hormuz will be open under joint international authority. Within 60 days, Iran's nuclear program will be verified to remain at its current degraded state, with no advancement permitted. We have preserved every American base. We have lost no additional American lives. And we have laid the foundation for a permanent regional architecture that protects American interests. This is what maximum pressure looks like when it works."

Islamic Republic of Iran:

"Today the Islamic Republic of Iran has secured the termination of the unjustified war imposed upon our nation by the United States and Israel. The American naval blockade of our ports will be lifted within 7 days. Our sovereign property, frozen for years, is returning to the Iranian nation in tranches that begin today. The Strait of Hormuz, our sovereign waterway, will be governed by an international authority on which Iran holds a permanent seat — replacing decades of American unilateralism. Our nuclear rights remain inviolable; our constitutional governance is unaffected; our sovereignty is intact. The Iranian nation has prevailed."

B.2 Day 7 — Hormuz reopening

United States:

"The Strait of Hormuz is open. Project Freedom delivered. Twenty percent of global oil and gas supply is back in motion. American gas-pump prices are coming down."

Islamic Republic of Iran:

"The Strait of Hormuz, jointly governed under sovereign Iranian co-equality, has been reopened to international commerce. The American blockade of Iranian ports has been lifted. Iranian commerce returns to global circulation."

B.3 Day 30 — First sanctions tranche and asset transfer

United States:

"Verified Iranian compliance with Stage 1 commitments has triggered the first tranche of Iranian sovereign property restitution under Congressional review. Aviation safety parts licenses are now active for Iranian commercial aviation, addressing a longstanding civilian safety concern. American agricultural exports to Iran are reopened. Verification continues on the nuclear standstill."

Islamic Republic of Iran:

"Iran's frozen sovereign property returns to the Iranian nation in the first major tranche. Iran Air resumes safe operations with international parts. The first commercial doors reopen between Iran and the global economy. The trajectory is restoration, not concession."

B.4 Day 90 — Permanent IHTA conversion

United States:

"The International Hormuz Transit Authority is now permanent. Freedom of navigation in the world's most important maritime chokepoint is institutionalized in international treaty law, with the United States holding a permanent voting seat. Iran can no longer unilaterally close the Strait without committing a treaty violation. This is a permanent gain for American interests and the global economy."

Islamic Republic of Iran:

"The International Hormuz Transit Authority is now permanent, with Iran holding a permanent governance seat with chair authority on alternating years. The unilateral American order in the Strait is replaced with formal Iranian co-equality. Hormuz transit revenue funds Iranian civilian reconstruction. Iranian sovereignty over the northern Strait is recognized."

B.5 Authorized Terminology Registry — selected entries

Concept	Authorized factual term
Iran's commitments under the Accord	Sovereign reciprocal commitments. Not 'concessions' or 'capitulation'.
US lifting of naval blockade	Lifting of the naval blockade. Not 'reparations' or 'tribute'.
Asset return	Return of Iranian sovereign property; restitution. Not 'payment' from US side; not 'reparations' from Iranian side.
Hormuz tolls	Navigation Service Charges. Standard maritime cost-recovery.
Nuclear deferral	Verified non-advancement standstill. Not 'freeze' (which connotes US-imposed); not 'pause' (which connotes Iran-imposed).
Project Freedom transition	Transition to multilateral convoy support. Iran characterizes as replacement of unilateralism; US characterizes as success of Project Freedom.
Lebanon track	Parallel track under separate framework. Not 'bundled' (which Iran rejects); not 'excluded' (which US rejects).
Iranian governance	Constitutional governance preserved. No characterization of legitimacy or illegitimacy.
The war	The 2026 conflict. Each government may characterize origins per its sovereign narrative.

Appendix C — Cross-Reference to Source Frameworks

This Accord draws extensively from existing framework architectures developed for the broader US-Iran and regional stabilization project. The following cross-reference identifies the source of each major architectural element. Source frameworks remain authoritative for elements not addressed in this Accord.

Accord element	Source framework	Source location
International Hormuz Transit Authority architecture	RAMES v9.1; RAMES v8.5 Annex GG; CBSF v15; Crescent Compact Part I-8	RAMES Point 8; Annex GG full architecture
Tolling and revenue allocation	RAMES v9.1; RCSA Economic Modules; CBSF v15	RAMES Point 8 Navigation Service Charges; RCSA Module 1.2
Asset return tranche structure	RAMES v9.1; CBSF v15; Crescent Compact I-4	RAMES Point 7; CBSF v13/v14 chained amendments
Sanctions relief sequencing and snapback friction ladder	RAMES v9.1; RCSA Economic Modules; CBSF v15 Snapback	RAMES Point 10; RCSA Module II Sanctions Synchronization
Three-channel mediation (Pakistan / Oman / Switzerland)	Emergency Extension Plan v1.7; RAMES v8.5	EEP Section 1B Dual-Channel; RAMES Three-Node Architecture
24-hour cooling-off rule	Emergency Extension Plan v1.7	EEP Section 3
Stabilization Holds	CRSF v4.3; Crescent Compact A2 90-Day Stabilization Window	EEP Section 1; Crescent Compact A2
Joint Implementation Group	RAMES v9.1; Crescent Compact Part III-1 (JCC adapted)	RAMES JIG; Crescent Compact JCC
Public Wins Ledger	Crescent Compact J-0 / S10 / 11 Additions	Crescent Compact v1.7 NEW
Joint Communication Windows and Authorized Terminology Registry	Crescent Compact J-3; Annex G	Crescent Compact Annex G; J-3
Third-Party Spoiler Attribution Protocol (TSAP)	RAMES v9.1 Point 13; CBSF v14 CH28	RAMES TSAP; CBSF Crisis Lock
Five de-escalation pathways	RAMES v9.1 Point 13; Crescent Compact S7	RAMES Joint Minimalist Floor
Verified nuclear non-advancement standstill	Crescent Compact I-2 / I-3; RCSA WPC	Crescent Compact Nuclear Dignity Doctrine; RCSA Wartime Entry Protocol
Dual-blockade synchronized resolution	RCSA v1.6.3 Wartime Entry and Post-Conflict Baseline Protocol	RCSA WPC Maritime Security Framework
Section 123 Agreement architecture	RAMES v8.5; RCSA Verification Modules	RAMES Section HH.3.2-D
Bipartisan Quorum Engineering	RCSA Political Domestic Stability Modules	RCSA PDM-2.5
Sovereignty milestone narrative architecture	RCSA Addendum B Stress-Tested Hardening	RCSA Addendum B Section 8 Sovereignty Milestones

Accord element	Source framework	Source location
Houthi Red Sea operational pause	RAMES v8.5 Annex EE; Crescent Compact Part V	RAMES EE.2 Option Alpha
Westphalian dispute resolution principles	Emergency Extension Plan; CRSF v4.3	EEP Integrated Frameworks
Waltz Philosophy of synchronized reciprocal motion	RAMES; CRSF; CBSF Preamble; Emergency Extension Plan	Foundational across all source frameworks

C.1 Successor framework pathway

On Day 180, the comprehensive successor framework is opened for negotiation. The Accord anticipates three possible successor instruments, all of which are compatible with this Accord's deliverables:

- **The Comprehensive Regional Stabilization Architecture (RCSA v1.6.3 or successor.)** The most ambitious of the three; addresses the full regional configuration including Iran, Israel, Lebanon, Yemen, Iraq, Syria, and the Israeli-Palestinian question.
- **The Crescent Compact (v1.7 or successor.)** A modular architecture allowing parties to ratify only the modules they accept; bilateral US-Iran modules can be ratified independently of regional modules.
- **RAMES (v9.1 or successor.)** Focused on the bilateral US-Iran-Israel triangle with specific architecture for nuclear, missile, and proxy issues.

Each of these instruments is designed to incorporate the Accord's Stage 1, Stage 2, and Stage 3 deliverables as their operational baseline. The Accord is therefore not a competitor to these instruments; it is the bridge that makes them possible.

Closing Note

This Accord exists because, on May 3, 2026, the United States and the Islamic Republic of Iran are technically at peace and operationally on the edge of resumed warfare. Project Freedom escorts begin May 4. Iran's parliament is moving on a 12-point Hormuz statute. The 9-point and 14-point proposals are exchanged but not closing. Gas in the United States is \$4.45 per gallon and the midterm clock is running. The IRGC remains on "full standby." President Trump has said he is "not satisfied." Iran's deputy foreign minister has said "the ball is in America's court."

There is a window now in which a deferred, sequenced, sovereignty-respecting instrument can close. The window will not be open indefinitely. The Hormuz First Accord is what that instrument could look like.

This document is a diplomatic reference instrument prepared on May 3, 2026 for consideration by negotiators, mediators, and policy advisors. It synthesizes the United States 9-point ceasefire proposal, the Islamic Republic of Iran's 14-point peace framework, and the institutional architectures developed in the Comprehensive Regional Stability Architecture (RCSA), the Reciprocal Accord for Middle East Stability (RAMES), the Crescent Compact, the Calibrated Bilateral Stabilization Framework (CBSF), and the Emergency Extension Plan. It is not a draft treaty; it is a framework for one. It is offered without claim of authority and without prejudice to the sovereign decisions of either government.

Document title	The Hormuz First Accord — A Nuclear-Deferred Emergency Stabilization Plan
Version	1.0 — Hormuz First
Date of issue	Sunday, May 3, 2026
Status	Diplomatic reference draft for negotiation
Successor pathway	RCSA v1.6.3 / Crescent Compact v1.7 / RAMES v9.1 (any one)
Mediation	Pakistan (primary) · Oman (technical) · Switzerland (financial)
Validation	All sections fully developed; no truncation.